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Technocratic vs Partisan Framing in Regional Fiscal Politics: Experimental Evidence from Spain

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ABSTRACT

How do citizens evaluate complex public policies when information is limited, and responsibility attribution is unclear? This paper examines the causal impact of source cues on attitudes toward subnational fiscal policies and the extent to which political alignment conditions citizens' responses. Using an original survey of 1,501 adults in Galicia (Spain) we implement two randomized survey experiments that vary the attribution of identical policy statements across technocratic and partisan sources. The experiments cover two policy domains that differ in complexity and opinion crystallization: policy evaluation for improving public spending efficiency and a reform of the regional fiscal framework. Results show that source cues significantly shape opinion formation, primarily by reducing uncertainty and activating partisan reasoning. Their effects are modest when citizens hold well-defined prior preferences but become substantially stronger in complex and unfamiliar policy domains. Moreover, responses are systematically conditioned by political alignment: individuals are less supportive of proposals associated with opposing parties and more supportive when the same proposals are endorsed by their preferred party. These findings provide new evidence on the role of source cues as mechanisms of uncertainty reduction and preference formation in multilevel governance settings.

Keywords: Source cues; Motivated reasoning; Partisanship; Survey experiments; Fiscal federalism; Public opinion

JEL classification: D72; D83; H77; D91; C93

1. INTRODUCTION

Understanding how citizens form opinions about public policies is central to evaluating the functioning of democratic systems. In contexts where information is complex and costly to acquire, individuals are likely to rely on heuristic cues, such as the identity of the actors conveying political claims, rather than on the substantive content of those claims. These dynamics are particularly relevant in decentralized settings, where multiple levels of government share responsibilities and where attributing policy outcomes to specific actors is often difficult. This paper provides causal evidence on how source cues and political alignment shape individuals' attitudes toward subnational fiscal policies and reforms.

The Spanish region of Galicia provides a particularly interesting case study. The regional government (so-called “Xunta de Galicia”) is a single-party executive with an absolute majority, while parliamentary competition is structured around a limited number of parties, resulting in clear government–opposition blocs.¹ This setting offers a suitable environment to test whether citizens respond differently to technocratic versus partisan sources. More broadly, Spanish regional governments (“Comunidades Autónomas” in Spanish) enjoy a high degree of fiscal and policy authority in comparative perspective and play a central role in the provision of key welfare-state services (health, education, and social services). As a result, regional debates over fiscal resources and the quality of public spending are politically salient and closely linked to perceptions of government performance and legitimacy.

The empirical analysis is based on two survey experiments. In both cases, respondents evaluate identical statements whose attributed source varies between a technocratic and a partisan actor. Because respondents are randomly assigned to conditions, this research design allows us to isolate the causal effect of source cues on opinion formation: whether citizens respond primarily to the substance of policy claims or whether they rely on source cues and engage in motivated reasoning. The first experiment examines attitudes toward the use of policy evaluation instruments to enhance the efficiency of public expenditure. The second experiment investigates preferences over a radical reform that would transition from the current, essentially federal system of regional financing to a confederal-type fiscal regime.

This paper contributes to the literature on political behaviour, public opinion, and multilevel governance in three ways. First, it extends existing research on source cues and motivated reasoning to the domain of subnational fiscal policy, a field that remains relatively underexplored from the perspective of preference formation and political information processing. Second, it shows that the impact of source cues depends on the informational environment in which citizens form their preferences. By comparing policy domains that differ in terms of public familiarity and opinion crystallization, the paper demonstrates that source cues become particularly influential when citizens face complex policies and high levels of uncertainty. Third, it provides evidence that political alignment

¹ The Parliament of Galicia (2024–2028) comprises 75 deputies: the Partido Popular de Galicia (PPdeG)—a conservative/right-wing party—holds 40 seats and governs with absolute majority; the opposition includes the Bloque Nacionalista Galego (BNG)—left-wing Galician nationalist—with 25 seats, the PSdeG-PSOE—social democratic/left-centre—with 9 seats, and Democracia Ourensana (DO)—localist/populist—with 1 seat.

systematically conditions how citizens process policy information. The findings reveal that source cues not only shape policy evaluations but also contribute to the formation of policy preferences, linking motivated reasoning with broader debates on institutional complexity, multilevel governance, and preference formation in contemporary democracies.

The remainder of the paper is structured as follows. Section 2 reviews the relevant literature. Section 3 describes the empirical research design, presents the main descriptive statistics, and outlines the econometric specifications. Section 4 presents and discusses the empirical results. Finally, Section 5 concludes by summarizing the paper's main findings and discussing their implications.

2. LITERATURE REVIEW

Understanding how citizens acquire and process political information has been a central concern in political economy and political behaviour since the seminal work of Downs (1957). In Downs' framework, citizens require information to participate in rationally democratic decision-making, yet acquiring such information is costly in terms of time and resources. In any case, the democratic process moves away from the conditions of knowledge that guarantee an outcome consistent with citizens' preferences (Somin, 2013; Achen and Bartels, 2016). In this gap, citizens who have more difficulty obtaining information can use shortcuts or heuristics to behave as if they were perfectly informed (Lupia, 1994). For this task, political parties are the main candidates, especially for hurried voters, those with some partisan attachment, or those who engage in so-called "retrospective voting". They remain the main avenue, either directly (Lau and Redlawsk, 2006) or through their effect on the positions of the media, for the formation of voters' opinions (Patterson and Donsbach, 1996; Falck et al., 2020; Guerrero-Solé, 2022), even under conditions of some difficulty in assigning responsibilities, such as governments with several parties in coalition (Fortunato et al., 2021) or multi-level government.

In this context, polarization affects the effectiveness of shortcuts in improving the outcomes of the political process. A distinction can be made between ideological polarization—related to specific issues—and social, or affective, polarization (Mason, 2015 and 2016). The former refers to disagreements over policy issues, the latter reflects increasingly negative attitudes toward political opponents and stronger emotional attachment to one's own political camp. This latter dimension has important implications for information processing because it shapes how individuals evaluate political messages and the actors who deliver them.

In the United States and Europe, there is evidence about a growing affective polarisation (Bishop, 2008; Gentzkow and Shapiro, 2011; Gentzkow, 2016; Reiljan 2020; Röllicke, 2023; and Wagner, 2024), although with important cross-country differences. Spain constitutes a particularly relevant case, exhibiting both ideological and territorial forms of polarization (Rodríguez et al., 2022; Torcal and Zoe, 2023). Political divisions have been reinforced by ideological competition (Orriols and León, 2021; Orriols, 2021) and territorial conflicts linked to competing national identities (Hierro and Gallego, 2018), most notably during the Catalan independence process (Guntermann, 2017; Guntermann et al., 2020).

Affective or social polarization also shapes how individuals interpret and respond to political information. Research shows that polarization is reinforced by party strategies

that emphasize political conflict and ideological differentiation (Bullock, 2011; Druckman et al., 2013; Guntermann and Blais, 2022), particularly during election campaigns (Sood and Iyengar, 2016). These dynamics are amplified by social interactions within politically homogeneous groups and echo chambers, where individuals are disproportionately exposed to congruent viewpoints (Hobolt et al., 2024). Media framing further contributes to perception gaps across political groups (Crespo et al., 2021), while digital communication environments facilitate processes of self-reinforcement and radicalization (Törnberg, 2018). Indeed, Lerman et al. (2024) argue that affective polarization has become a structural feature of contemporary information networks.

Within this context, source cues become particularly relevant. Existing research suggests that citizens evaluate information not solely on its substantive content but also on the identity of the actor communicating it. Gunterman (2017) provides particularly relevant evidence from experimental studies conducted in Catalonia and Galicia. Comparing information presented with and without party labels, he finds that political parties significantly shape citizens' responses, although the magnitude of these effects depends on individual identity, prior knowledge of party positions and the degree of conflict between competing political actors. Related work suggests that the impact of source cues is also conditioned by the degree of opinion crystallization (Tesler, 2015) and the personal relevance of the issue under consideration (Mullinix, 2016).

More broadly, recent research highlights the importance of trust and prior beliefs in shaping citizens' reactions to information. The COVID-19 pandemic provided a natural setting to examine how individuals evaluate different sources of information (Quían, et al., 2023). Building on this line of inquiry, Young, et al. (2025) show that individuals may interpret identical information differently depending on their prior political beliefs. Their explanation is that citizens tend to discount information that contradicts their existing views because they perceive such information as less independent or less credible. This mechanism provides a micro-foundation linking source cues, motivated reasoning, and political polarization.

Taken together, the existing literature suggests that citizens' frequent reliance on informational shortcuts is conditioned by partisan identities, prior beliefs, and levels of political polarization. A significant body of literature has analysed the difficulties that the existence of different levels of government causes for the attribution of responsibilities by citizens (Anderson, 2006; Benjamin, 2017; Wlezien and Soroka, 2011); also for Spain (Herrero-Alcalde et al., 2017; Lago and Lago-Peñas, 2010; Lago and Lago-Peñas, 2013; León, 2010 and 2012; López and Rodrigo, 2015). But studies are scarcer, and focused on the local level, when it comes to analysing the role of parties as shortcuts (Boudreau et al., 2015; Painter and Kimball, 2022).

So, much less is known about how these mechanisms (source cues) operate in policy domains characterized by high levels of institutional complexity and informational uncertainty, particularly in multilevel governance settings where responsibility attribution is often difficult, and citizens possess limited prior knowledge. Understanding how citizens form preferences under such conditions constitutes an important challenge for the study of political behaviour. In these contexts, source cues may function not only as informational shortcuts but also as mechanisms through which citizens reduce uncertainty and form political preferences.

3. EMPIRICAL APPROACH

3.1. Research design

The empirical research is based on an ad-hoc survey designed specifically for this study. The questionnaire was designed to combine detailed socio-demographic and political information with embedded experimental variation. In particular, the survey includes two randomized experiments aimed at identifying the causal effect of source cues on individual attitudes toward public policy. The experimental design employs a minimal-variation wording protocol: respondents are exposed to substantively identical statements with randomized messenger attribution across conditions, enabling clean identification of messenger effects independent of message content through exogenous variation in attribution. Hence, differences in outcomes can be interpreted as causal effects of source attribution.

The survey was conducted in June 2025, targeting adults aged 18 and over. Data were collected via an online panel administered by the market research and data collection company Netquest between June 10 and June 30, yielding a final sample of 1,501 completed interviews. The sample is broadly representative of the adult population in Galicia with respect to key socio-demographic characteristics.

The first experiment focuses on attitudes toward using policy evaluation tools to improve the efficiency and effectiveness of public spending at the regional level. In the control condition, the statement is attributed to a technocratic institution: *“The Spanish Independent Authority for Fiscal Responsibility (AIReF) argues that the Autonomous Communities should make greater efforts in policy evaluation to improve the efficiency and effectiveness of public spending.”* In the treatment condition, the same statement is attributed to the parties of the opposition: *“The opposition in the Parliament of Galicia argues that the Xunta should make greater efforts in policy evaluation to improve the efficiency and effectiveness of public spending.”* Respondents indicate their level of agreement on a four-point ordinal scale (*strongly agree, agree, disagree, strongly disagree*) with an additional *“Don’t know”* category. This design enables the distinction not only of directional opinion shifts but also of changes in the propensity to express uncertainty.

The second experiment examines preferences regarding a major change to the regional financing system, namely, a shift to a confederal fiscal system for Galicia, similar to the one currently applied in the Basque Country and Navarre, called *“régimen foral”* in Spanish. Under this institutional arrangement, subnational governments exercise near-full tax autonomy, collecting and administering most of the taxes within their jurisdiction, including the personal income tax, the value-added tax and the corporate tax, and subsequently remit a negotiated lump-sum grant to the central government to finance non-devolved competencies. From a comparative fiscal federalism perspective, this model is more accurately characterized as confederal rather than federal, given the high degree of fiscal sovereignty retained at the subnational level (Lago-Peñas et al., 2017). In the control group, the proposal is attributed to an unspecified technocratic source: *“Some analysts say that a foral fiscal system would be more beneficial for Galicia than the current financing system because the Xunta would have more resources than at present. Do you agree?”* In the treatment group, the same proposal is explicitly linked to the only political party defending the change, the *Galician Nationalist Bloc (BNG)*: *“The BNG considers that a foral fiscal system would be more beneficial for Galicia than the current financing system because the Xunta would have more resources than at present. Do you*

agree?” Responses are recorded using three categories (*Yes, No, Don’t know*). As in the first experiment, random assignment ensures that treatment and control groups are comparable, allowing observed differences in responses to be interpreted as causal effects of source attribution.

Beyond the experimental components, the survey includes a wide range of attitudinal variables on public policies and institutional performance. A key variable for the empirical analysis is satisfaction, constructed as the average of eight items (question P15 on the survey), capturing respondents’ evaluations of core public services provided or coordinated by regional governments. Specifically, the index aggregates satisfaction with: (i) healthcare services, (ii) early and primary education, (iii) secondary education and vocational training, (iv) university education, (v) dependent-care services, (vi) housing policies, (vii) environmental protection, and (viii) research, development, and innovation policies. Each item is measured on a 0–5 scale ranging from “*not satisfied at all*” to “*fully satisfied*,” and the composite indicator thus provides a synthetic measure of perceived public service performance across key welfare domains.

The questionnaire also captures additional attitudinal dimensions, including beliefs about public services (P14), knowledge of the allocation of policy responsibilities across levels of government (P13), and knowledge of the Basque–Navarre *foral* fiscal system (P27), all of which are relevant for interpreting how individuals process policy-related information. A complete definition of all variables used in the empirical analysis is provided in **Table 1**.

[Insert Table 1 here]

The analysis proceeds in two steps. First, we estimate baseline models capturing the average effect of source cues. Second, and more importantly, we examine whether individuals’ responses depend on their political alignment with the actor associated with the message. This second step is not simply an exploration of heterogeneity but a direct test of ideological belief formation, in which individuals accept or reject policy proposals conditional on the source’s partisan identity.

The three main hypotheses to be tested are as follows:

H1. Technocratic Hypothesis. Technical authorities are more reliable for citizens than political parties.

H2. Uncertainty Reduction Hypothesis. Partisan source cues reduce indecision by decreasing the probability that individuals select “Don’t know” responses.

H3. Partisan Endorsement Hypothesis. The interaction between the partisan source cue and individuals’ political alignment is a primary determinant of the degree of support for a proposal.

3.2. Descriptive statistics

Table 2 contains summary statistics for the continuous and categorical variables and provides an overview of socio-demographic characteristics, political preferences, and baseline attitudes of the respondents. The sample displays a balanced distribution across key demographic characteristics. The average age is 48.2 years, with a standard deviation of 12.8, and the gender distribution is nearly even between male and female respondents. Household composition is also heterogeneous, with an average household size slightly above 2 members and roughly one-third of respondents reporting children under 18 in the household.

Educational attainment is predominantly concentrated in medium and high levels, with each accounting for approximately half of the sample, while individuals with low levels of education represent a small minority. On employment status, private-sector employees constitute the largest group (around 41%), followed by public-sector workers and retirees. Income, measured in ranges, is distributed nearly equally among the three central categories, with a 9% below 1,000€ and 8% over 5,000€. Turning to political variables, respondents exhibit meaningful heterogeneity in both ideological positioning and electoral behaviour. On average, individuals place themselves slightly to the left of the ideological midpoint (mean 4.74 on a 1–10 scale).

Baseline attitudes toward the policy domains under study differ markedly across the two experiments. In the case of policy evaluation, support is already high in the absence of treatment effects: a clear majority of respondents express agreement with the statement, suggesting that preferences in this domain are relatively well-formed and broadly consensual. In contrast, the distribution of responses in Experiment 2 shows uncertainty regarding fiscal federalism reforms. Nearly half of the respondents chose the “Don’t know” option when asked about the introduction of a *foral* system for Galicia, indicating limited prior knowledge and a low degree of opinion crystallisation.

Taken together, these descriptive patterns suggest that the experimental interventions operate in two distinct informational environments: one in which individuals hold relatively well-formed prior beliefs (policy evaluation) and another characterized by high levels of uncertainty and limited familiarity (fiscal reform). This contrast provides a particularly suitable setting to assess the extent to which source cues shape opinion formation, especially through their role in reducing indecision.

[Insert Table 2]

3.3. Specifications and econometrics

In Experiment 1, the dependent variable measures agreement with a statement advocating greater use of policy evaluation tools, expressed on an ordinal scale with four categories (*strongly agree*, *agree*, *disagree*, *strongly disagree*) plus a “Don’t know” option. To account for the nature of this outcome, we estimate both ordered-logit and multinomial-logit specifications.

The ordered logit model, excluding the “Don’t know” category, assumes an underlying latent propensity to agree:

$$y_i^* = \alpha + \beta T_i + \lambda S_i + \gamma X_i + \varepsilon_i \quad [1]$$

Where *Treatment* (T_i) indicates whether the statement is attributed to a partisan actor (the opposition) rather than a technocratic source (AIREF), and *Satisfaction* (S_i) denotes the respondent's average satisfaction with public services.

To explicitly account for uncertainty in responses, as captured by the “*Don't know*” category, we also estimate a multinomial logit specification including all response categories:

$$\Pr(Y_i = k) = \frac{\exp(\alpha_k + \beta_k T_i + \lambda_k S_i + \gamma_k X_i)}{\sum_j \exp(\alpha_j + \beta_j T_i + \lambda_j S_i + \gamma_j X_i)} \quad [2]$$

In Experiment 2, where the outcome variable is nominal (*Yes*, *No*, *Don't know*), we rely exclusively on a multinomial logit model of the same form:

$$\Pr(Y_i = k) = \frac{\exp(\alpha_k + \beta_k T_i + \lambda_k F_i + \gamma_k X_i)}{\sum_j \exp(\alpha_j + \beta_j T_i + \lambda_j F_i + \gamma_j X_i)} \quad [3]$$

In this specification, *Treatment* (T) is a binary indicator capturing whether the policy proposal is attributed to a partisan source (the BNG) rather than to a neutral, technocratic source (“some analysts”). In turn, *Foral* (F_i) captures respondents' self-reported level of knowledge of the Basque–Navarre *foral* fiscal system, which serves as a proxy for prior knowledge of the institutional setting underlying the proposed reform. Its inclusion allows us to account for the fact that individuals with greater prior knowledge are likely to hold more structured preferences and therefore rely less on source cues when forming their responses.

Across all models, the vector X_i includes socio-demographic characteristics (gender, age, education, income, household structure), contextual variables (municipality size), and political attributes (ideology, vote choice, and territorial identity).

The core contribution of the empirical analysis lies in testing whether individuals react to policy statements based on who conveys the message rather than its content, in a manner consistent with partisan alignment. This is H3 hypothesis. To do so, we extend the baseline specification by interacting the treatment indicator with respondents' political alignment with the message's source. The resulting model can be written as:

$$\Pr(Y_i = k) = \frac{\exp(\alpha_k + \beta_k T_i + \delta_k A_i + \theta_k (T_i * A_i) + \lambda_k Z_i + \gamma_k X_i)}{\sum_j \exp(\alpha_j + \beta_j T_i + \delta_j A_i + \theta_j (T_i * A_i) + \lambda_j Z_i + \gamma_j X_i)} \quad [4]$$

where *Alignment* (A) captures whether the respondent is politically aligned with the actor referenced in the treatment condition, using their vote in the last regional election. Variable Z represents the specific control for each experiment, *Satisfaction* (S_i) on experiment 1 and *Foral* (F_i) on experiment 2.

In Experiment 1, the statement in the treatment condition is attributed to the parliamentary opposition. We therefore define alignment in terms of support for the incumbent party (*PP*). The key question is whether PP voters react negatively to the same policy proposal when it is associated with the opposition, consistent with a logic of partisan rejection. A negative interaction effect would indicate that support declines

specifically among government-aligned voters when the message originates from a rival political actor.

By contrast, in Experiment 2, the proposal for the treatment group is attributed to the nationalist party, which claims a confederal financing system (BNG). In this case, alignment is defined as having voted for that party. We test whether BNG voters show an outsized increase in support when the proposal is explicitly tied to their favoured party, following the logic of partisan endorsement. A positive interaction effect would indicate that support is amplified among aligned voters when the message carries a partisan label.

In both cases, the interaction term θ captures a deviation from the average treatment effect that is systematically related to political alignment. Rather than reflecting generic heterogeneity, these interaction effects provide direct evidence on whether individuals engage in motivated reasoning, accepting or rejecting identical policy proposals depending on their partisan origin.

Because logit coefficients do not have a straightforward interpretation in terms of changes in probability, all results are presented as Average Marginal Effects (AMEs). For each outcome category k , the AME of the treatment (and its interaction with political alignment) is defined as:

$$AME_k = \left(\frac{1}{N}\right) \sum_i \left(\frac{\partial \Pr(Y_i = k)}{\partial T_i} \right) \quad [5]$$

When interactions are included, marginal effects are computed separately for relevant subgroups (aligned vs non-aligned voters), allowing for a direct assessment of how source cues differentially affect opinion formation. In addition, we complement the tabular presentation of AMEs with graphical displays of predicted probabilities.

4. RESULTS

4.1. Experiment 1: Policy evaluation and opposition cues

The frequency distributions (**Figure 1**) reveal an asymmetry across treatment conditions. When the statement is attributed to a technocratic source (AIREF), agreement levels are slightly higher, whereas attributing the same message to the political opposition reduces uncertainty and increases disagreement categories. In particular, the share of “Don’t know” responses decreases in the treatment condition, from approximately 10.1% under the control condition to 7.1% when the statement is attributed to the opposition, suggesting that partisan cues reduce indecision and push respondents toward taking a position.

[Insert Figure 1 here]

The results of the baseline models are reported in **Table 3**. The ordered logit specification indicates that the treatment effect is small and not statistically significant, suggesting that, on average, attributing the statement to the opposition does not significantly affect agreement levels. However, the multinomial logit model reveals a more nuanced pattern. While the treatment effect on agreement categories remains statistically insignificant, there is a large and highly significant reduction in the probability of selecting the “Don’t know” category. The average marginal effects indicate

that treatment exposure decreases the likelihood of a “*Don’t know*” response by around 8.1 percentage points. This reduction in uncertainty is partially offset by a small but statistically significant increase in strong disagreement, together with modest changes in the remaining response categories. At the same time, this reduction in uncertainty is distributed across both agreement and disagreement categories, with small and statistically weak changes in individual outcomes. This suggests that the primary effect of partisan cues in this context is not to systematically shift preferences in one direction but rather to induce respondents to take a stance.

[Insert Table 3 here]

Figure 2 further illustrates this mechanism. Predicted probabilities show a clear decline in the likelihood of indecision under treatment, accompanied by corresponding increases in both agreement and disagreement probabilities, although the magnitude of these changes remains modest.

[Insert Figure 2 here]

Further insights emerge when splitting the sample by political alignment (**Figure 3**). Among non-PP voters, the distribution is generally consistent with the overall distribution, but with an increase in the agreement categories and a reduction in disagreement. In contrast, the pattern is noticeably different among PP voters, for whom support for the statement drops sharply in the treatment condition and disagreement responses rise substantially. This pattern is consistent with a mechanism of partisan rejection, where individuals aligned with the incumbent party discount or oppose policy proposals when they are associated with political rivals.

[Insert Figure 3 here]

We next estimate interaction models in specification [4] to formally test whether responses to source cues are conditioned by political alignment. The results shown in **Table 4** provide evidence consistent with ideological belief formation, whereby individuals’ evaluations depend on the partisan identity of the message source. Among non-PP voters, treatment exposure has a weak and statistically insignificant effect on most outcome categories, though it slightly increases the probability of strong agreement. By contrast, among PP voters, the treatment triggers a clear and statistically significant shift away from agreement and toward disagreement.

The estimated average marginal effects or AME in equation [5] show that, conditional on being a PP voter, attributing the statement to the opposition reduces the probability of strong agreement by approximately 10 percentage points and increases the probability of disagreement by around 14 percentage points. This asymmetric reaction provides direct evidence of partisan rejection: identical policy proposals are evaluated differently depending on whether they are associated with a rival political actor. This interpretation is supported by **Figure 4**. While predicted probabilities are relatively stable across treatment conditions for non-PP voters, they diverge noticeably for PP voters, who show lower agreement and higher disagreement in the presence of the partisan cue.

[Insert Figure 4 here]

4.2. Experiment 2: Fiscal reform and partisan endorsement

We next turn to Experiment 2, which examines support for a *foral* fiscal arrangement. Descriptive patterns reveal substantial differences across treatment conditions. When the proposal is attributed to independent analysts, a large share of respondents selects the “*Don’t know*” option. By contrast, attributing the proposal to the BNG leads to a sharp reduction in uncertainty and a substantial increase in expressed support. Specifically, **Figure 5** shows that the share of “*Don’t know*” responses falls from 27.9% in the control group to 21.4% under treatment, while the proportion of *Yes* and *No* responses increases.

[Insert Figure 5 here]

Table 5 presents the multinomial logit estimates for Experiment 2. The treatment effect is large and statistically significant across several outcome categories. The average marginal effects indicate that attributing the proposal to the BNG increases the probability of supporting the reform (*Yes*) by approximately 11.9 percentage points, while reducing the likelihood of a “*Don’t know*” response by about 15.8 percentage points. There is also a smaller and only marginally statistically significant increase in the probability of rejection (*No*), which suggests that the partisan cue polarizes opinions rather than simply shifting them uniformly toward support.

[Insert Table 5 here]

Figure 6, which shows predicted probabilities, highlights these dynamics clearly. The treatment leads to a reallocation of probability mass away from the “*Don’t know*” category toward both support and opposition, with a particularly strong effect on the probability of supporting the proposal.

[Insert Figure 6 here]

When disaggregating by political alignment (**Figure 7**), the contrast becomes even more pronounced. Among BNG voters, support for the proposal increases strongly under treatment, whereas among non-BNG voters, the increase in support is more limited and accompanied by a rise in opposition.

[Insert Figure 7 here]

Finally, we estimate specification [4] to examine whether the treatment effect varies according to support for the BNG. The interaction models show strong evidence of partisan endorsement effects. Among BNG voters, treatment exposure leads to a large and statistically significant increase in support for the proposal. The AMEs in **Table 6** indicate that the probability of answering *Yes* increases by approximately 25.7 percentage points, while the probability of selecting “*Don’t know*” decreases significantly. In contrast, among non-BNG voters, the effect on support is small and not statistically significant, while treatment exposure is associated with a significant increase in opposition (*No*) and a reduction in the share of “*Don’t know*” responses. These results suggest that partisan cues not only reduce uncertainty but also activate alignment-based responses, amplifying support among those who identify with the message’s source while increasing opposition among non-aligned individuals. This mechanism is illustrated using the presentation of predicted probabilities. **Figure 8** shows a significant increase in support among BNG voters with the partisan-cue wording, while the changes among non-aligned respondents are rather small.

[Insert Table 6 here]

[Insert Figure 8 here]

5. CONCLUSION

This paper examines how source cues shape individual attitudes toward public policies, with a particular focus on the role of partisan polarization in mediating these effects. Using two survey experiments embedded in an original dataset for Galicia, the analysis provides causal evidence on how identical policy proposals are evaluated differently depending on the identity of the actor conveying the message.

The results yield three main findings. First, source cues have limited impact on average policy preferences in contexts where opinions are already well-formed. In both experiments, attributing the statement to a partisan actor does not significantly alter aggregate levels of agreement. Second, the treatment substantially reduces the incidence of “Don’t know” responses, indicating that source cues play an important role in reducing uncertainty and inducing respondents to take a position. Third, and most importantly, the analysis provides clear evidence of belief formation dependent on party cleavage. The interaction results show that responses to source cues are systematically conditioned by political alignment. In Experiment 1, individuals aligned with the incumbent party react negatively to a proposal when it is associated with the opposition, consistent with a mechanism of partisan rejection. In Experiment 2, voters aligned with the sponsoring party exhibit a strong increase in support when the proposal is explicitly attributed to that party, reflecting partisan endorsement.

Taken together, these findings add to a growing body of work highlighting the role of informational shortcuts and partisan cues in the development of public opinion. More specifically, the results highlight that source cues increase divergence between political groups while decreasing aggregate-level uncertainty.

Our findings also have broader implications for the design and communication of public policies. In politically polarized environments, the credibility and effectiveness of policy proposals may depend not only on their substantive content but also on the identity of the actors endorsing them. This suggests that technocratic framing may be more effective in generating broad consensus, whereas partisan endorsement can mobilize support among aligned groups at the cost of increasing polarization.

Future work might expand this analysis by exploring the temporal persistence of these effects, their interaction with media environments, and their implications for policy implementation. In particular, an important avenue for future study is how repeated exposure to partisan cues shapes long-term belief formation.

Data availability statement

Replication data and code are publicly available in the Harvard Dataverse repository at <https://doi.org/10.7910/DVN/TUSIYV>. These materials allow full reproduction of the empirical analyses reported in the article.

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Conflicts of interest

The authors declare no conflict of interest.

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Writing - review and editing: Cadaval-Sampedro, Lago-Peñas, and Fernández-Leiceaga

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Table 1. Variable description

Variable	Description	Coding / Scale
Experiment variables		
experiment1	Agreement with the statement on the need for greater policy evaluation in Autonomous Communities.	Categorical: 1 = Strongly agree, 2 = Agree, 3 = Disagree, 4 = Strongly disagree, 98 = Don't know
treatment1	Treatment indicator for Experiment 1.	Binary: 1 if the statement is attributed to opposition political actors, 0 if attributed to AIREF (technocratic source)
experiment2	Support for adopting a <i>foral</i> fiscal system for Galicia.	Categorical: 1 = Yes, 2 = No, 98 = Don't know
treatment2	Treatment indicator for Experiment 2.	Binary: 1 if the proposal is attributed to the BNG, 0 if attributed to independent analysts
PPvote	Indicator for voting for Partido Popular (PP) in the last regional election.	Binary: 1 = PP voter, 0 = otherwise
BNGvote	Indicator for voting for Bloque Nacionalista Galego (BNG) in the last regional election.	Binary: 1 = BNG voter, 0 = otherwise
Political variables		
ideology	Self-placement on the left–right ideological spectrum.	Scale from 1 (extreme left) to 10 (extreme right)
identity	Self-reported territorial identity on a nationalist-regionalist ideological spectrum.	Scale from 1(National identity) to 5 (Regional identity)
vote	Vote choice in the last regional election.	Categorical: PP, BNG, PSOE/PSdeG, DO, Vox, Sumar Galicia, Other, None
Key explanatory variables		
satisfaction	Average level of satisfaction with public services. Constructed as the mean of eight survey items (P15 battery).	Continuous index ranging from 0 to 5
foral	Knowledge of the Basque–Navarre <i>foral</i> fiscal system.	Categorical: 1 = Knows perfectly, 2 = Knows fairly well, 3 = Not very well, 4 = Does not know
Socio-demographic controls		
sex	Gender of the respondent.	Binary: 1 = Female, 0 = Male
age	Age of the respondent.	Continuous (years)
education	Highest level of educational attainment.	Categorical: Low, Medium, High
work	Employment status.	Categorical: Self-employed, Private employee, Public employee, Retired, Student, Housework, Unemployed
household	Number of individuals in the household.	Continuous
kids	Presence of children under 18 in the household.	Binary: 1 = Yes, 0 = No
income	Household income category.	Categorical: 1 = <1,000€; 2 = 1,000€–2,000€; 3 = 2,001€–3,000€; 4 = 3,001€–5,000€; 5 = 5,001–8,000€; 6 = >8,000€; 98 = DK/NA
size	Inhabitants of the respondent municipality	Continuous

Table 2. Descriptive statistics

Continuous Variables"					
	N	Mean	Std. Dev.	Min	Max
age	1,501	48.23	12.81	18	97
size	1,501	11,7011	111,023	789	294,489
household	1,501	2.63	1.10	1	7
ideology	1,501	4.74	1.96	1	10
identity	1,501	3.14	0.80	1	5
satisfaction	1,501	2.20	1.00	0	5
Categorical Variables"					
				Freq	Percent
Gender identity					
Male				735	48.97%
Female				766	51.03%
Education					
Low education				40	2.66%
Medium education				730	48.63%
High education				731	48.70%
Employment and labour market status					
Self-employed				120	7.99%
Private sector employee				621	41.37%
Public sector employee				267	17.79%
Retired/Pensioner				224	14.92%
Student				47	3.13%
Housework				61	4.06%
Unemployed				161	10.73%
Children under 18 in the household					
Yes				427	33.05%
No				865	66.95%
Monthly gross household income					
<1,000€				107	8.76%
1,000€–2,000€				343	28.09%
2,001€–3,000€				359	29.40%
3,001€–5,000€				320	26.21%
5,001€–8,000€				77	6.31%
>8,000€				15	1.23%
Vote in the last regional elections					
PP				295	19.65%
BNG				383	25.52%
PSOE/PSdeG				291	19.39%
DO				6	0.40%
Vox				51	3.40%
Sumar Galicia				54	3.60%
Other				56	3.73%
None				365	24.32%
Knowledge of the Basque–Navarre <i>foral</i> fiscal system					
Yes, perfectly				65	4.33%
Yes, fairly well				334	22.25%
Not very well				540	35.98%
No				562	37.44%

Table 3. AME results for Experiment 1 with no interactions

	Ologit				Mlogit (With DK option)				
	SA	A	D	SD	SA	A	D	SD	DK
Treatment	-0.020 (-0.73)	0.009 (0.73)	0.009 (0.73)	0.001 (0.71)	0.041 (1.52)	-0.002 (-0.07)	0.031 (1.61)	0.011 (1.88)*	-0.081 (-3.84)***
<i>N</i>	854				987				

Note: The table reports average marginal effects (AMEs) from ordered- and multinomial-logit models. Z-statistics are reported in parentheses. Statistical significance is denoted as follows: *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$. Response-category abbreviations: SA = Strongly Agree; A = Agree; D = Disagree; SD = Strongly Disagree; DK = Don't Know. All models include socio-demographic and political controls (gender, age, education, income, household, ideology, vote, and identity), as well as experiment-specific control "satisfaction".

Table 4. AME results for Experiment 1 with interactions

	Ologit				Mlogit (With DK option)				
	SA	A	D	SD	SA	A	D	SD	DK
Not PP voter	0.036 (1.08)	-0.022 (-1.08)	-0.013 (-1.08)	-0.001 (-1.04)	0.083 (2.62)***	-0.002 (-0.05)	0.001 (0.03)	0.004 (0.59)	-0.086 (-3.51)
PP voter	-0.140 (-3.12)***	-0.057 (-1.78)*	0.166 (3.33)***	0.032 (2.35)**	-0.111 (-2.23)**	-0.022 (-0.33)	0.148 (2.55)**	0.036 (1.75)*	-0.051 (-1.16)***
<i>N</i>	854				987				

Note: The table reports average marginal effects (AMEs) from multinomial logit models. Z-statistics are reported in parentheses. Statistical significance is denoted as follows: *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$. Response-category abbreviations: SA = Strongly Agree; A = Agree; D = Disagree; SD = Strongly Disagree; DK = Don't Know. All models include socio-demographic and political controls (gender, age, education, income, household, ideology, vote, and identity), as well as experiment-specific control "satisfaction".

Table 5. AME results for Experiment 2 with no interactions

	Yes	No	DK
Treatment	0.119 (4.24)***	0.043 (1.87)*	-0.162 (-5.80)***
N	987		

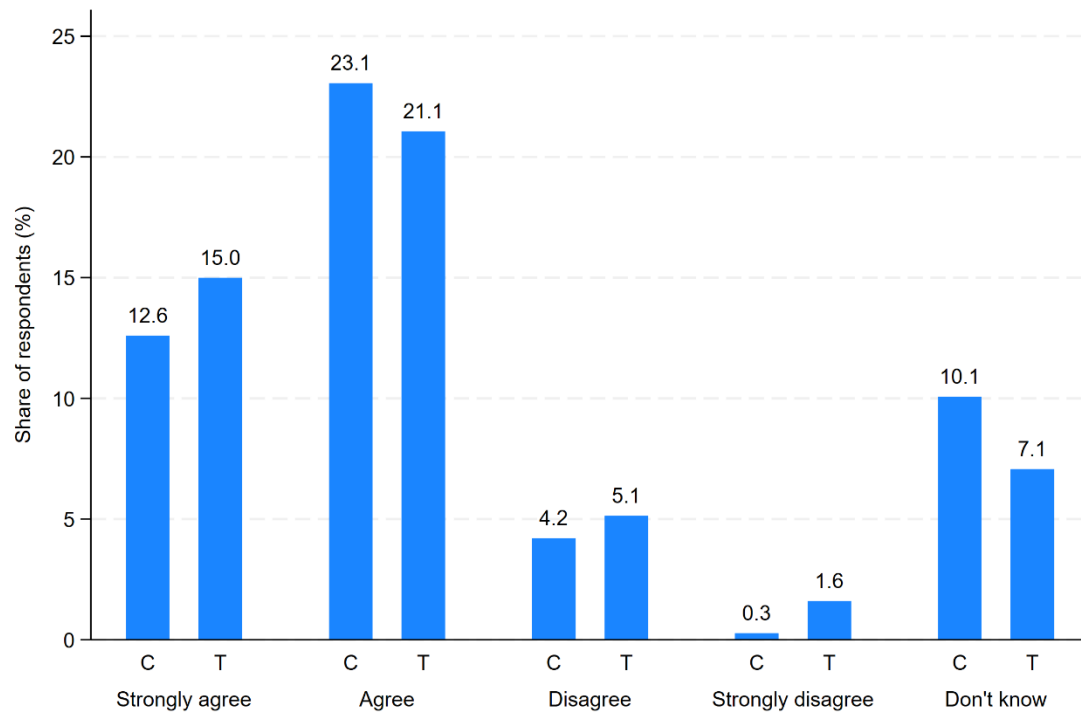
Note: The table reports average marginal effects (AMEs) from multinomial logit models. Z-statistics are reported in parentheses. Statistical significance is denoted as follows: *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$. Response-category abbreviations: DK = Don't Know. All models include socio-demographic and political controls (gender, age, education, income, household, ideology, vote, and identity), as well as experiment-specific control "*foral*".

Table 6. AME results for Experiment 2 with interactions

	Yes	No	DK
Not BNG voter	0.048 (1.42)	0.086 (2.92)***	-0.134 (-3.94)***
BNG voter	0.248 (4.69)***	-0.044 (-1.26)	-0.204 (-4.04)***
N	987		

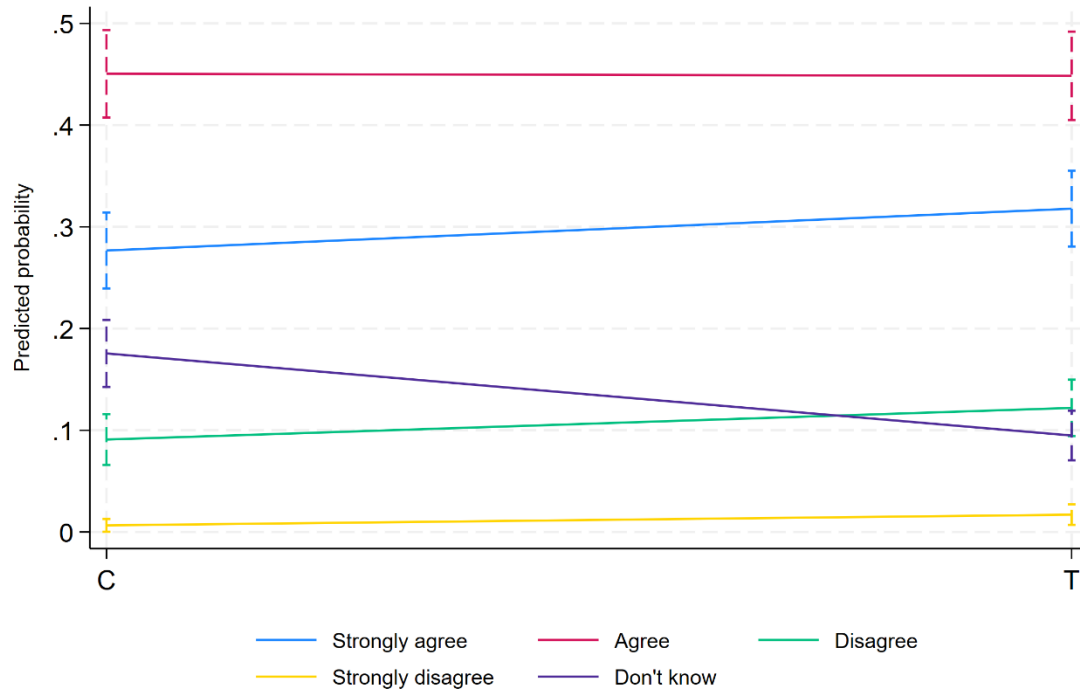
Note: The table reports average marginal effects (AMEs) from multinomial logit models. Z-statistics are reported in parentheses. Statistical significance is denoted as follows: *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$. Response-category abbreviations: DK = Don't Know. All models include socio-demographic and political controls (gender, age, education, income, household, ideology, vote, and identity), as well as experiment-specific control "*foral*".

Figure 1. Distribution of Responses by Treatment Condition (Experiment 1)



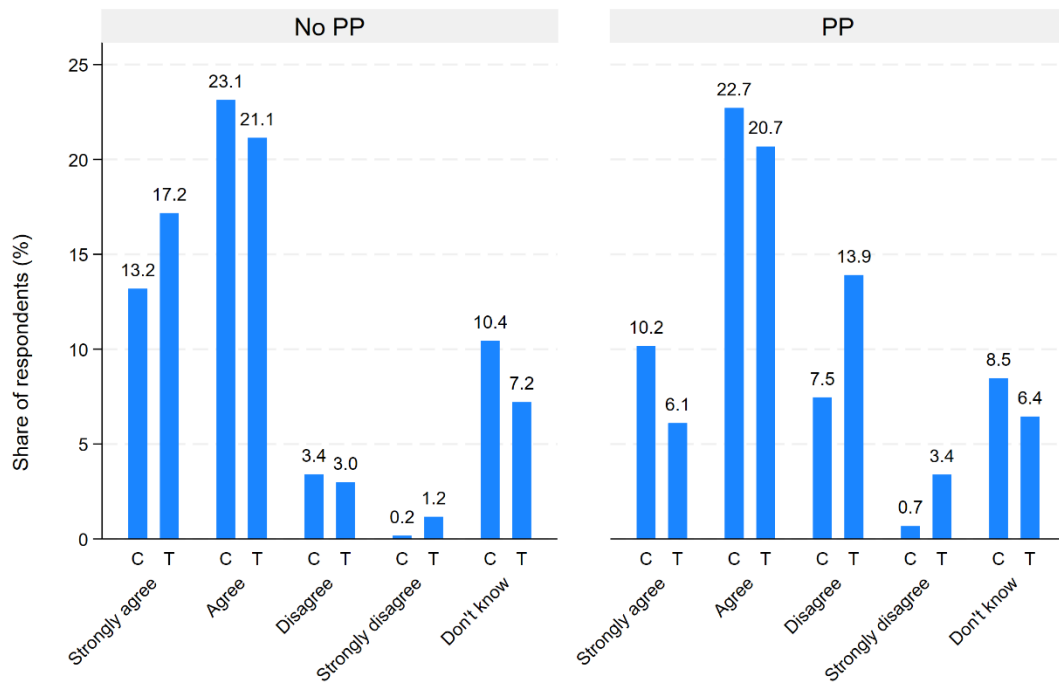
Notes: Responses to Question P25 on policy evaluation. The statement is attributed either to the technocratic source AIREF (Control) or to the parliamentary opposition (Treatment). C denotes control and T treatment.

Figure 2. Predicted Probabilities by Treatment Condition (Experiment 1)



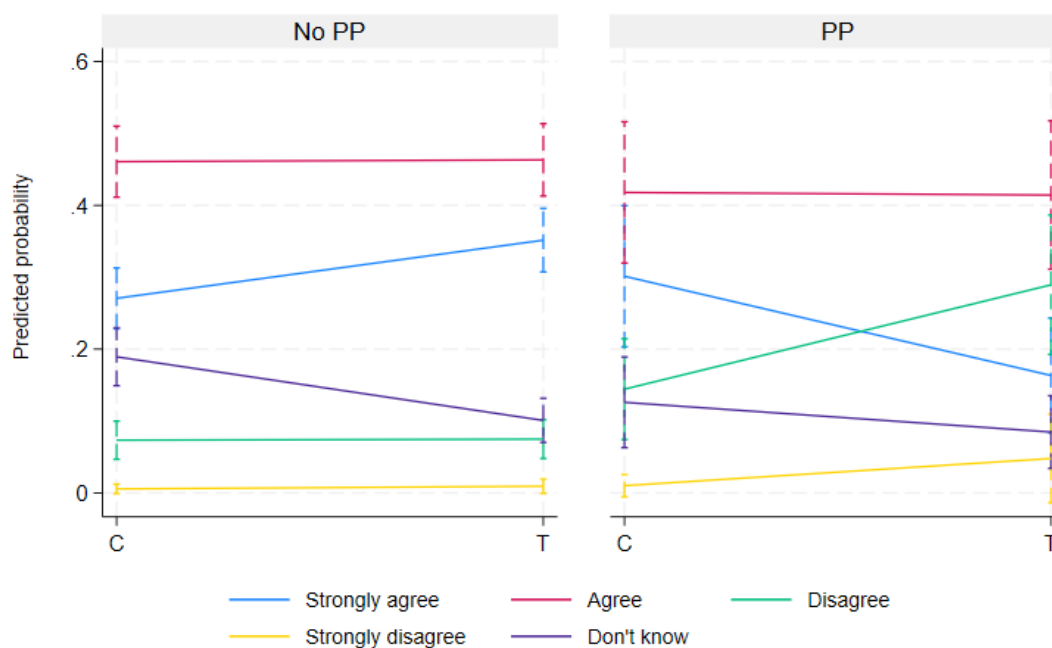
Notes: Predicted probabilities are computed from multinomial logit models including the full set of controls, with all other covariates held at their observed values. Responses correspond to Question P25 on policy evaluation, where the statement is attributed either to the technocratic source AIReF (Control) or to the parliamentary opposition (Treatment). C denotes control and T treatment.

Figure 3. Distribution of Responses by Treatment and PP Vote (Experiment 1)



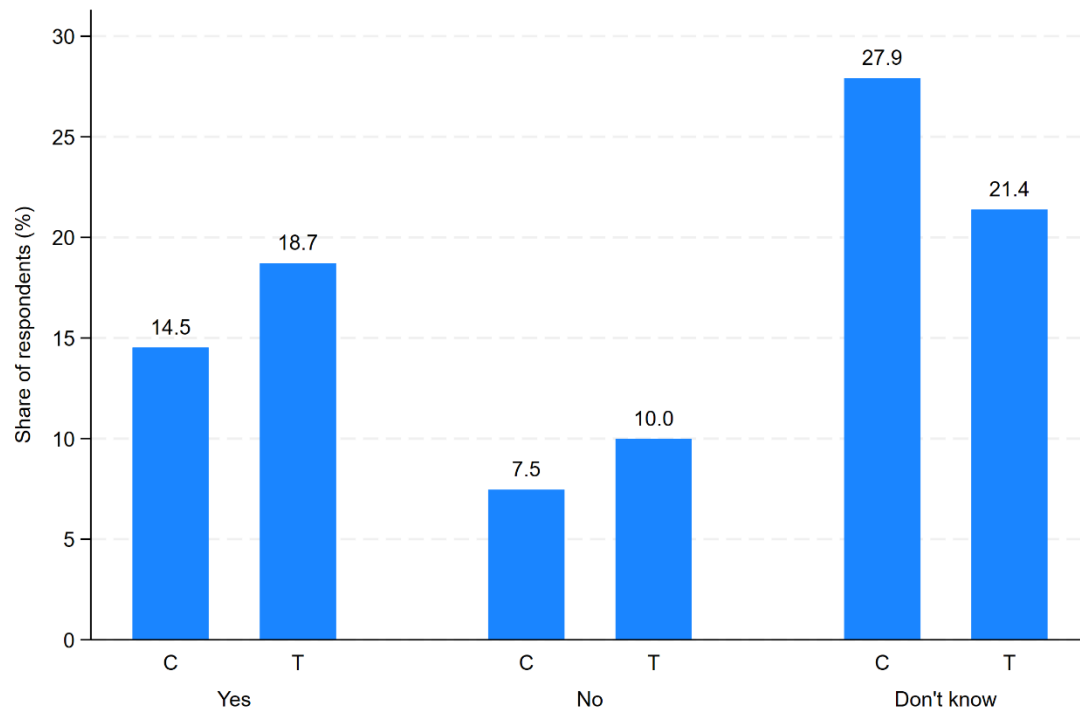
Notes: Responses to Question P25 on policy evaluation. The statement is attributed either to the technocratic source AIReF (Control) or to the parliamentary opposition (Treatment). Results are shown separately for PP and non-PP voters. C denotes control and T treatment.

Figure 4. Predicted Probabilities by Treatment and PP Vote (Experiment 1)



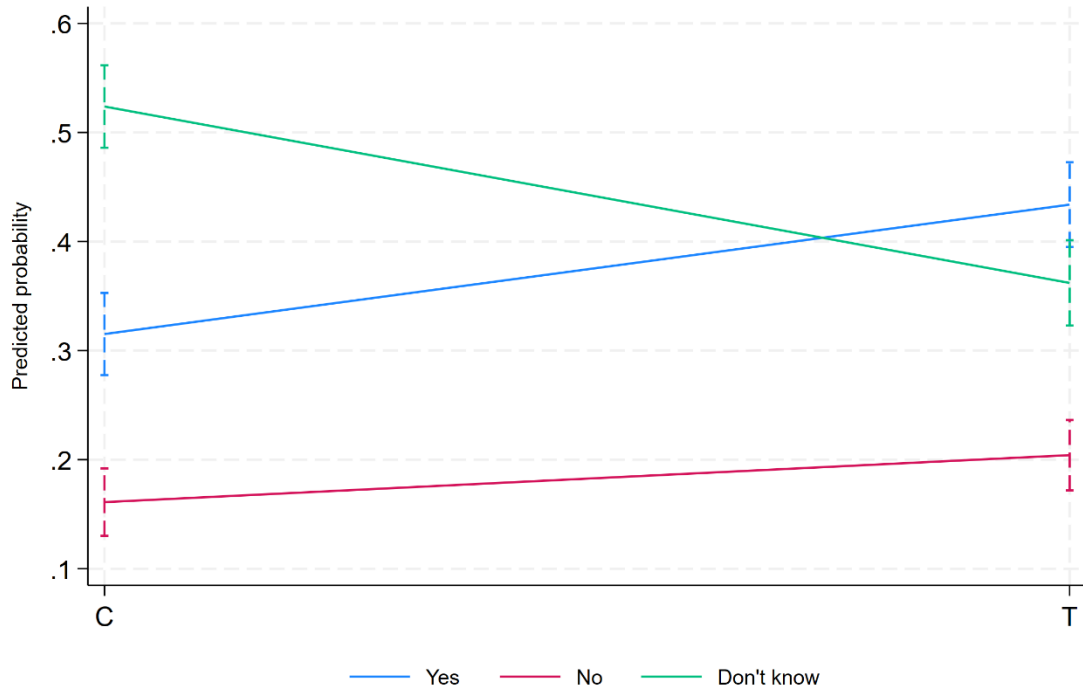
Notes: Predicted probabilities are computed from multinomial logit models including the full set of controls, with all other covariates held at their observed values. Responses correspond to Question P25 on policy evaluation, where the statement is attributed either to the technocratic source AIReF (Control) or to the parliamentary opposition (Treatment). Results are shown separately for PP and non-PP voters. C denotes control and T treatment.

Figure 5. Distribution of Responses by Treatment Condition (Experiment 2)



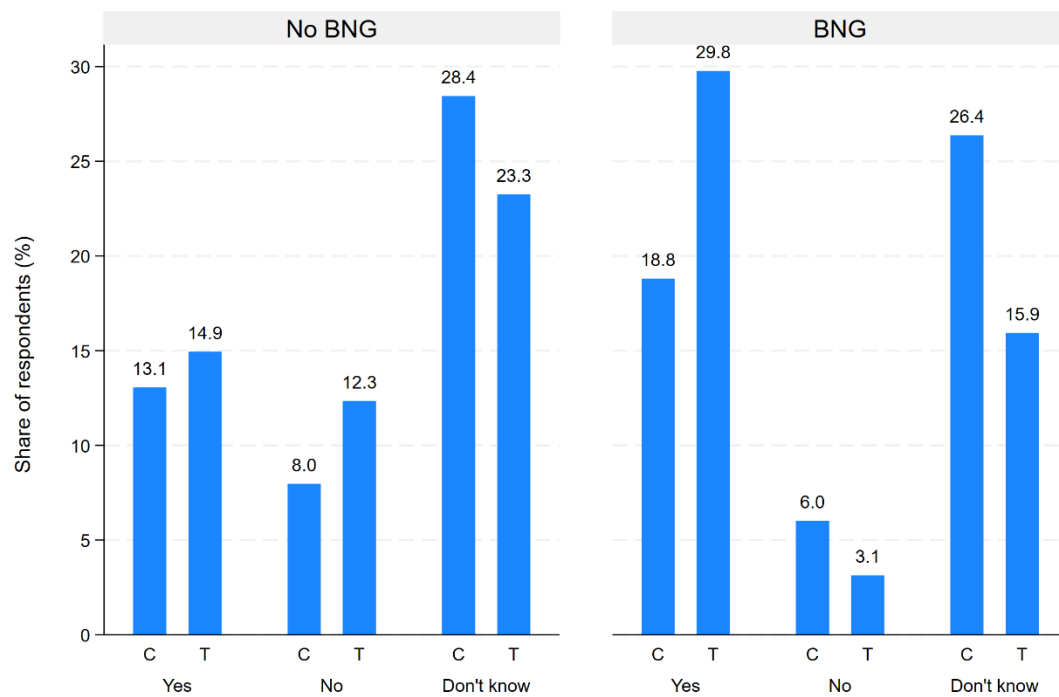
Notes: Responses to Question P28 on support for a *foral* fiscal system. The proposal is attributed either to independent analysts (Control) or to the BNG (Treatment). C denotes control and T treatment.

Figure 6. Predicted Probabilities by Treatment Condition (Experiment 2)



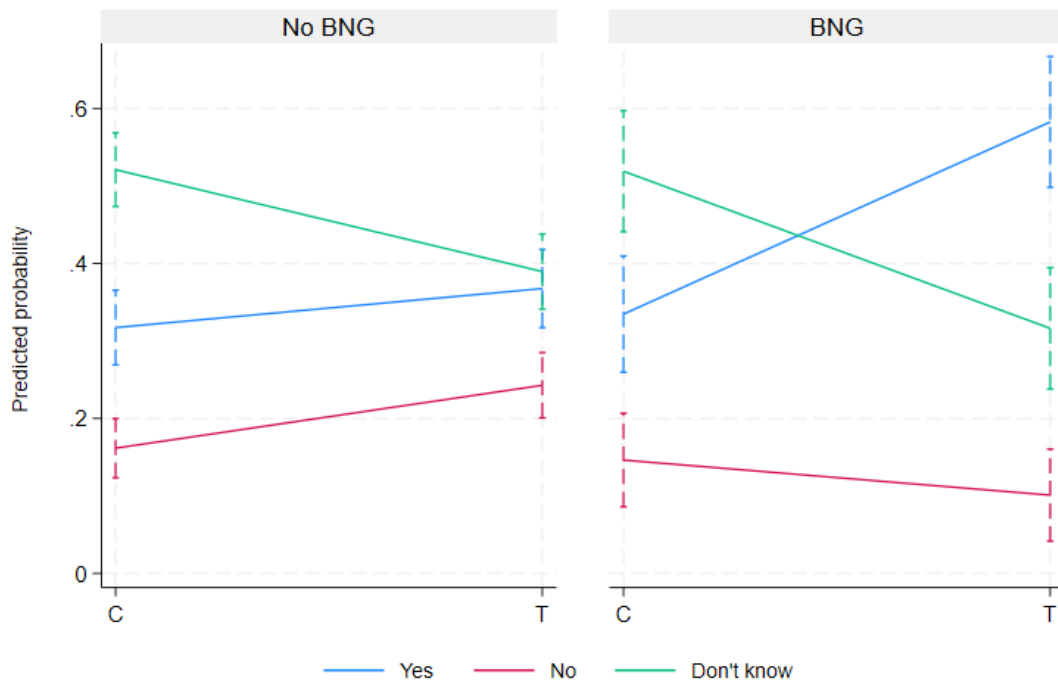
Notes: Predicted probabilities are computed from multinomial logit models including the full set of controls, with all other covariates held at their observed values. Responses correspond to Question P28 on support for a *foral* fiscal system, where the proposal is attributed either to independent analysts (Control) or to the BNG (Treatment). Results are shown separately for BNG and non-BNG voters. C denotes control and T treatment.

Figure 7. Distribution of Responses by Treatment and BNG Vote (Experiment 2)



Notes: Responses to Question P28 on support for a foral fiscal system. The proposal is attributed either to independent analysts (Control) or to the BNG (Treatment). Results are shown separately for BNG and non-BNG voters. C denotes control and T treatment.

Figure 8. Predicted Probabilities by Treatment and BNG Vote (Experiment 2)



Notes: Predicted probabilities are computed from multinomial logit models including the full set of controls, with all other covariates held at their observed values. Responses correspond to Question P28 on support for a foral fiscal system, where the proposal is attributed either to independent analysts (Control) or to the BNG (Treatment). C denotes control and T treatment.

Appendix A. Estimation results

Table A1. Estimation results for the Ordered Logit Model on Experiment 1

Level of agreement on P25 on policy evaluation	
Experiment 1 (AIReF vs Opposition) [Base category: AIReF]	
Treatment (Opposition)	0.100 (0.73)
Gender identity [Base category: Male]	
Female	0.356 (2.22)**
Age	
	-0.015 (-1.98)**
Inhabitants in the municipality	
	-0.000 (-1.70)*
Highest completed education level (3 categories) [Base category: Low education]	
Medium education	0.691 (0.87)
High education	0.494 (0.62)
Employment and labour market status [Base category: Self-employed]	
Private sector employee	-0.125 (-0.46)
Public sector employee	0.137 (0.47)
Retired/Pensioner	0.009 (0.03)
Student	0.101 (0.20)
Housework	-0.241 (-0.54)
Unemployed	-0.570 (-1.58)
Household size (number of members)	
	-0.033 (-0.37)
Children under 18 in the household [Base category: Yes]	
No	0.172 (1.03)
Monthly gross household income [Base category: <1,000€]	
1,000€–2,000€	-0.178 (-0.43)
2,001€–3,000€	-0.351 (-0.88)
3,001€–5,000€	-0.227 (-0.55)
5,001€–8,000€	-0.646 (-1.40)
>8,000€	-1.043 (-1.47)
Vote in the last regional elections [Base category: PP]	
BNG	-0.967 (-3.64)***
PSOE/PSdeG	-1.110 (-4.34)***
DO	0.287 (0.68)
Vox	-0.928 (-2.18)**
Sumar Galicia	-0.415

Level of agreement on P25 on policy evaluation	
	(-0.88)
Other	-1.505
	(-3.45)***
None	-0.572
	(-2.44)**
Left–right ideological self-placement (1–10)	0.100
	(1.84)*
National identity (Spanish/Galician scale)	-0.152
	(-1.49)
Average level of satisfaction with public services (P15)	0.302
	(3.46)***
Cut1	-1.222
Cut2	1.621
Cut3	4.121
N	854
Pseudo R-squared	0.08

Note: Z-statistics are reported in parentheses. Statistical significance is denoted as follows: *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$. P25: “[*The Independent Authority for Fiscal Responsibility (AIReF)*]/[*The opposition in the Parliament of Galicia*] argues that the Autonomous Communities should make greater efforts in policy evaluation to improve the efficiency and effectiveness of public spending.”

Table A2. Estimation results for the Multinomial Logit Model on Experiment 1

Agreement on P25 on policy evaluation [Base outcome: D]	SA	A	SD	DK
Experiment 1 (AIReF vs Opposition) [Base category: AIReF]				
Treatment (Opposition)	-0.149 (-0.59)	-0.319 (-1.36)	0.687 (1.17)	-0.983 (-3.47)***
Gender identity [Base category: Male]				
Female	-0.568 (-2.09)**	-0.423 (-1.67)*	0.142 (0.17)	-0.052 (-0.17)
Age				
	0.018 (1.34)	-0.006 (-0.49)	-0.014 (-0.37)	-0.017 (-1.12)
Inhabitants in the municipality				
	0.000 (0.89)	-0.000 (-0.78)	-0.000 (-0.56)	0.000 (0.40)
Highest completed education level (3 categories) [Base category: Low education]				
Medium education	-0.858 (-1.25)	1.272 (1.48)	-1.188 (-1.16)	-0.585 (-0.81)
High education	-0.321 (-0.45)	1.702 (1.95)*	-0.693 (-0.57)	-0.450 (-0.60)
Employment and labour market status [Base category: Self-employed]				
Private sector employee	0.186 (0.40)	0.049 (0.11)	13.831 (16.57)***	1.103 (1.83)*
Public sector employee	-0.159 (-0.31)	0.101 (0.21)	14.788 (11.91)***	0.897 (1.38)
Retired/Pensioner	0.309 (0.55)	0.460 (0.89)	14.999 (13.79)***	1.256 (1.77)*
Student	-0.320 (-0.33)	-0.357 (-0.45)	-1.339 (-1.10)	0.170 (0.18)
Housework	0.816 (0.94)	0.988 (1.24)	15.113 (8.72)***	1.726 (1.87)*
Unemployed	1.036 (1.64)	0.584 (0.98)	14.246 (11.86)***	2.087 (2.77)***
Household size (number of members)				
	-0.002 (-0.01)	-0.069 (-0.50)	0.007 (0.02)	0.052 (0.32)
Children under 18 in the household [Base category: Yes]				
No	-0.374 (-1.23)	-0.293 (-1.02)	0.704 (0.82)	0.332 (0.98)
Monthly gross household income [Base category: <1,000€]				
1,000€–2,000€	0.222 (0.35)	0.031 (0.05)	-0.498 (-0.44)	-0.305 (-0.51)
2,001€–3,000€	0.489 (0.76)	0.309 (0.54)	-2.243 (-1.48)	-0.505 (-0.82)
3,001€–5,000€	0.376 (0.57)	0.160 (0.27)	-1.363 (-1.01)	-0.240 (-0.38)
5,001€–8,000€	0.921 (1.17)	0.476 (0.67)	-15.983 (-11.84)***	0.008 (0.01)
>8,000€	1.357 (1.23)	0.391 (0.35)	-13.310 (-9.18)***	0.403 (0.36)
Vote in the last regional elections [Base category: PP]				
BNG	1.753 (3.79)***	1.364 (3.18)***	-0.509 (-0.37)	1.306 (2.49)**
PSOE/PSdeG	2.087 (4.15)***	1.665 (3.53)***	0.513 (0.55)	1.491 (2.65)***
DO	-16.065 (-16.56)***	0.399 (0.34)	-17.454 (-12.41)***	-16.506 (-10.66)***
Vox	1.365 (2.08)**	0.773 (1.27)	-14.856 (-15.44)***	0.168 (0.20)
Sumar Galicia	0.474	-0.023	-0.572	-0.460

Agreement on P25 on policy evaluation [Base outcome: D]	SA	A	SD	DK
	(0.81)	(-0.04)	(-0.42)	(-0.55)
Other	2.676 (2.37)**	1.937 (1.80)*	-12.815 (-8.23)***	2.580 (2.26)**
None	0.968 (2.49)**	1.143 (3.48)***	-0.318 (-0.28)	1.723 (4.43)***
Left–right ideological self-placement (1–10)	-0.167 (-1.89)*	-0.070 (-0.92)	-0.083 (-0.42)	-0.051 (-0.54)
National identity (Spanish/Galician scale)	0.064 (0.35)	-0.171 (-1.00)	-0.451 (-1.25)	-0.449 (-2.28)**
Average level of satisfaction with public services (P15)	-0.312 (-2.31)**	0.112 (0.91)	-0.144 (-0.30)	0.087 (0.57)
Intercept	0.698 (0.41)	0.612 (0.37)	-12.432 (-3.51)***	1.221 (0.67)
N	987			
Pseudo R-squared	0.12			

Note: Z-statistics are reported in parentheses. Statistical significance is denoted as follows: *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$. P25: “[*The Independent Authority for Fiscal Responsibility (AIReF)*]/[*The opposition in the Parliament of Galicia*] argues that the Autonomous Communities should make greater efforts in policy evaluation to improve the efficiency and effectiveness of public spending.”. Response-category abbreviations: SA = Strongly Agree; A = Agree; D = Disagree; SD = Strongly Disagree; DK = Don’t Know

Table A3. Estimation results for the Ordered Logit Model on Experiment 1 with vote PP interaction

Agreement on P25 on policy evaluation	
Experiment 1 (AIReF vs Opposition) [Base category: AIReF]	
Treatment (Opposition)	-0.165 (-1.09)
Voted for PP in last regional election [Base category: No PP]	
PP	0.208 (0.77)
Experiment 1 (AIReF vs Opposition) # Voted for PP	
Treatment (Opposition)#PP	1.249 (3.46)***
Gender identity [Base category: Male]	
Female	0.265 (1.73)*
Age	
	-0.019 (-2.51)**
Inhabitants in the municipality	
	-0.000 (-1.82)*
Highest completed education level (3 categories) [Base category: Low education]	
Medium education	0.761 (0.88)
High education	0.531 (0.61)
Employment and labour market status [Base category: Self-employed]	
Private sector employee	-0.175 (-0.64)
Public sector employee	0.104 (0.36)
Retired/Pensioner	0.044 (0.14)
Student	-0.033 (-0.06)
Housework	-0.221 (-0.51)
Unemployed	-0.581 (-1.65)*
Household size (number of members)	
	-0.014 (-0.16)
Children under 18 in the household [Base category: Yes]	
No	0.240 (1.43)
Monthly gross household income [Base category: <1,000€]	
1,000€–2,000€	-0.285 (-0.68)
2,001€–3,000€	-0.487 (-1.20)
3,001€–5,000€	-0.408 (-0.97)
5,001€–8,000€	-0.714 (-1.55)
>8,000€	-1.365 (-1.84)*
Left–right ideological self-placement (1–10)	
	0.120 (2.55)**
National identity (Spanish/Galician scale)	
	-0.178 (-1.78)*
Average level of satisfaction with public services (P15)	
	0.303 (3.53)***

Agreement on P25 on policy evaluation	
cut1	-0.700
cut2	2.151
cut3	4.671
N	854
Pseudo R-squared	0.08

Note: Z-statistics are reported in parentheses. Statistical significance is denoted as follows: *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$. P25: “[*The Independent Authority for Fiscal Responsibility (AIReF)*]/[*The opposition in the Parliament of Galicia*] argues that the Autonomous Communities should make greater efforts in policy evaluation to improve the efficiency and effectiveness of public spending.”

Table A4. Estimation results for the Multinomial Logit Model on Experiment 1 with vote PP interaction

Agreement on P25 on policy evaluation [Base outcome: D]	SA	A	SD	DK
Experiment 1 (AIReF vs Opposition) [Base category: AIReF]				
Treatment (Opposition)	0.303 (0.99)	-0.001 (-0.00)	0.446 (0.48)	-0.683 (-1.96)**
Voted for PP in last regional election [Base category: No PP]				
PP	-0.555 (-1.27)	-0.780 (-)	-0.106 (-0.13)	-1.109 (-2.37)**
Experiment 1 (AIReF vs Opposition) # Voted for PP				
Treatment (Opposition)#PP	-1.725 (-3.03)***	-0.735 (-1.52)	0.516 (0.35)	-0.415 (-0.67)
Gender identity [Base category: Male]				
Female	-0.457 (-1.75)*	-0.331 (-1.37)	0.225 (0.26)	0.036 (0.12)
Age	0.026 (1.88)*	-0.001 (-0.09)	-0.010 (-0.26)	-0.014 (-0.95)
Inhabitants in the municipality	0.000 (0.93)	-0.000 (-0.76)	-0.000 (-0.52)	0.000 (0.40)
Highest completed education level (3 categories) [Base category: Low education]				
Medium education	-0.715 (-0.88)	1.304 (1.40)	-1.264 (-1.22)	-0.556 (-0.67)
High education	-0.123 (-0.15)	1.778 (1.87)*	-0.765 (-0.63)	-0.447 (-0.52)
Employment and labour market status [Base category: Self-employed]				
Private sector employee	0.220 (0.48)	0.064 (0.15)	13.938 (15.86)***	1.012 (1.69)*
Public sector employee	-0.133 (-0.26)	0.095 (0.20)	14.865 (11.58)***	0.741 (1.13)
Retired/Pensioner	0.212 (0.40)	0.392 (0.78)	14.998 (12.12)***	1.048 (1.49)
Student	-0.091 (-0.09)	-0.170 (-0.21)	-0.650 (-0.46)	0.357 (0.36)
Housework	0.796 (0.93)	0.946 (1.20)	15.119 (7.85)***	1.598 (1.72)*
Unemployed	1.071 (1.74)*	0.602 (1.03)	14.363 (11.08)***	2.082 (2.81)***
Household size (number of members)	-0.035 (-0.24)	-0.097 (-0.70)	-0.020 (-0.05)	0.012 (0.08)
Children under 18 in the household [Base category: Yes]				
No	-0.488 (-1.58)	-0.371 (-1.28)	0.679 (0.83)	0.211 (0.63)
Monthly gross household income [Base category: <1,000€]				
1,000€–2,000€	0.493 (0.74)	0.246 (0.41)	-0.456 (-0.36)	-0.050 (-0.08)
2,001€–3,000€	0.829 (1.25)	0.578 (0.97)	-2.132 (-1.30)	-0.168 (-0.26)
3,001€–5,000€	0.732 (1.09)	0.424 (0.70)	-1.314 (-0.88)	0.017 (0.02)
5,001€–8,000€	1.187 (1.50)	0.683 (0.95)	-15.266 (-)	0.294 (0.36)
>8,000€	1.937 (1.67)*	0.759 (0.68)	-13.438 (-8.49)***	0.671 (0.57)
Left–right ideological self-placement (1–10)	-0.213 (-2.63)***	-0.082 (-1.14)	-0.147 (-0.73)	-0.019 (-0.22)
National identity (Spanish/Galician scale)	0.119 (0.64)	-0.141 (-0.82)	-0.484 (-1.44)	-0.416 (-2.09)**

Agreement on P25 on policy evaluation [Base outcome: D]	SA	A	SD	DK
Average level of satisfaction with public services (P15)	-0.332 (-2.41)**	0.100 (0.79)	-0.110 (-0.23)	0.066 (0.43)
Intercept	1.330 (0.77)	1.196 (0.70)	-12.447 (-3.91)***	2.043 (1.06)
N	987			
Pseudo R-squared	0.12			

Note: Z-statistics are reported in parentheses. Statistical significance is denoted as follows: *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$. P25: “[*The Independent Authority for Fiscal Responsibility (AIReF)*]/[*The opposition in the Parliament of Galicia*] argues that the Autonomous Communities should make greater efforts in policy evaluation to improve the efficiency and effectiveness of public spending.” Response-category abbreviations: SA = Strongly Agree; A = Agree; D = Disagree; SD = Strongly Disagree; DK = Don’t Know

Table A5. Estimation results for the Multinomial Logit Model on Experiment 2

Agreement on P28 on a <i>foral</i> fiscal system [Base outcome: NO]	YES	Don't know
Experiment 2 (Analysts vs BNG) [Base category: Analysts]		
Treatment (BNG)	0.122 (0.61)	-0.759 (-3.89)***
Gender identity [Base category: Male]		
Female	-0.251 (-1.12)	-0.061 (-0.28)
Age		
	0.007 (0.61)	-0.001 (-0.09)
Inhabitants in the municipality		
	-0.000 (-0.10)	0.000 (0.60)
Highest completed education level (3 categories) [Base category: Low education]		
Medium education	-0.747 (-1.09)	-0.625 (-0.90)
High education	-0.858 (-1.23)	-0.746 (-1.07)
Employment and labour market status [Base category: Self-employed]		
Private sector employee	-0.142 (-0.37)	-0.273 (-0.69)
Public sector employee	-0.474 (-1.14)	-0.489 (-1.14)
Retired/Pensioner	-0.609 (-1.32)	-0.673 (-1.43)
Student	-0.957 (-1.24)	-0.366 (-0.49)
Housework	-0.851 (-1.16)	-0.399 (-0.60)
Unemployed	-0.189 (-0.38)	-0.679 (-1.32)
Household size (number of members)		
	0.258 (1.95)*	0.160 (1.20)
Children under 18 in the household [Base category: Yes]		
No	0.369 (1.43)	0.441 (1.74)*
Monthly gross household income [Base category: <1,000€]		
1,000€–2,000€	0.322 (0.60)	-0.203 (-0.39)
2,001€–3,000€	-0.101 (-0.19)	-0.342 (-0.66)
3,001€–5,000€	-0.197 (-0.36)	-0.230 (-0.43)
5,001€–8,000€	-0.157 (-0.25)	-0.047 (-0.08)
>8,000€	-0.739 (-0.89)	-0.981 (-0.97)
Vote in the last regional elections [Base category: PP]		
BNG	2.184 (6.01)***	0.657 (1.89)*
PSOE/PSdeG	1.821 (5.25)***	0.551 (1.66)*
DO	1.899 (1.45)	1.071 (0.64)
Vox	1.147 (2.25)**	-0.350 (-0.60)
Sumar Galicia	2.086 (3.36)***	-0.716 (-1.04)
Other	1.219	-0.103

Agreement on P28 on a <i>foral</i> fiscal system [Base outcome: NO]	YES	Don't know
	(2.17)**	(-0.17)
None	1.422	0.696
	(4.22)***	(2.28)**
Left-right ideological self-placement (1–10)	0.005	-0.077
	(0.07)	(-1.12)
National identity (Spanish/Galician scale)	0.318	0.119
	(2.38)**	(0.91)
Knowledge of the Basque–Navarre <i>foral</i> financing system [Base category: <i>Yes, perfectly</i>]		
Yes, fairly well	0.419	0.976
	(1.14)	(1.65)*
Not very well	0.520	2.625
	(1.37)	(4.53)***
No	0.171	3.193
	(0.42)	(5.39)***
Intercept	-2.174	-0.832
	(-1.60)	(-0.61)
N	987	
Pseudo R-squared	0.17	

Note: Z-statistics are reported in parentheses. Statistical significance is denoted as follows: *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$. P28: [*Some analysts say*]/[*The Galician Nationalist Bloc (BNG) considers*] that a *foral* fiscal system would be more beneficial for Galicia than the current financing system because the Xunta would have more resources than at present. Do you agree?

Table A6. Estimation results for the Multinomial Logit Model on Experiment 2 with BNG vote interaction

Agreement on P28 on a <i>foral</i> fiscal system [Base outcome: NO]	YES	Don't know
Experiment 2 (Analysts vs BNG) [Base category: Analysts]		
Treatment (BNG)	-0.276 (-1.24)	-0.830 (-3.83)***
Voted for BNG in last regional election [Base category: No BNG]		
BNG	0.161 (0.46)	0.100 (0.29)
Experiment 2 (Analysts vs BNG) # Voted for BNG		
Treatment (BNG) # BNG	1.249 (2.57)**	0.554 (1.09)
Gender identity [Base category: Male]		
Female	-0.214 (-0.97)	-0.018 (-0.08)
Age	0.001 (0.13)	-0.003 (-0.26)
Inhabitants in the municipality	-0.000 (-0.06)	0.000 (0.53)
Highest completed education level (3 categories) [Base category: Low education]		
Medium education	-0.743 (-1.13)	-0.573 (-0.83)
High education	-0.861 (-1.30)	-0.683 (-0.99)
Employment and labour market status [Base category: Self-employed]		
Private sector employee	-0.188 (-0.52)	-0.301 (-0.80)
Public sector employee	-0.465 (-1.17)	-0.514 (-1.24)
Retired/Pensioner	-0.644 (-1.46)	-0.716 (-1.58)
Student	-0.943 (-1.17)	-0.310 (-0.42)
Housework	-0.853 (-1.19)	-0.404 (-0.63)
Unemployed	-0.086 (-0.18)	-0.596 (-1.19)
Household size (number of members)	0.183 (1.42)	0.110 (0.82)
Children under 18 in the household [Base category: Yes]		
No	0.251 (0.97)	0.384 (1.48)
Monthly gross household income [Base category: <1,000€]		
1,000€–2,000€	0.140 (0.26)	-0.212 (-0.42)
2,001€–3,000€	-0.361 (-0.68)	-0.379 (-0.75)
3,001€–5,000€	-0.406 (-0.75)	-0.267 (-0.52)
5,001€–8,000€	-0.380 (-0.62)	-0.101 (-0.17)
>8,000€	-0.753 (-0.92)	-1.086 (-1.08)
Left–right ideological self-placement (1–10)	-0.168 (-2.92)***	-0.118 (-2.14)**
National identity (Spanish/Galician scale)	0.349 (2.61)***	0.130 (1.01)
Knowledge of the Basque–Navarre <i>foral</i> financing system [Base category: Yes, perfectly]		

Agreement on P28 on a <i>foral</i> fiscal system [Base outcome: NO]	YES	Don't know
Yes, fairly well	0.397 (1.12)	0.969 (1.63)
Not very well	0.553 (1.52)	2.593 (4.45)***
No	0.297 (0.75)	3.226 (5.42)***
Intercept	0.705 (0.54)	-0.089 (-0.07)
N	987	
Pseudo R-squared	0.15	

Note: Z-statistics are reported in parentheses. Statistical significance is denoted as follows: *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$. P28: [Some analysts say]/[The Galician Nationalist Bloc (BNG) considers] that a *foral* fiscal system would be more beneficial for Galicia than the current financing system because the Xunta would have more resources than at present. Do you agree?

Appendix B. Survey questions

B.1 Experimental variables

P25 - Policy evaluation (Experiment 1)

Control condition:

“The Independent Authority for Fiscal Responsibility (AIReF) argues that the Autonomous Communities should make greater efforts in policy evaluation to improve the efficiency and effectiveness of public spending.”

Treatment condition:

“The opposition in the Parliament of Galicia argues that the Xunta should make greater efforts in policy evaluation to improve the efficiency and effectiveness of public spending.”

Responses:

- 1 - Strongly agree
- 2 - Agree
- 3 - Disagree
- 4 - Strongly disagree
- 98 - Don't know

P28 - Foral fiscal system (Experiment 2)

Control condition:

“Some analysts say that a foral fiscal system would be more beneficial for Galicia than the current financing system because the Xunta would have more resources than at present. Do you agree?”

Treatment condition:

“The Galician Nationalist Bloc (BNG) considers that a foral fiscal system would be more beneficial for Galicia than the current financing system because the Xunta would have more resources than at present. Do you agree?”

Responses:

- 1 - Yes
- 2 - No
- 98 - Don't know

B.2 Political variables

P10 - Vote choice

“Which party did you vote for in the last regional elections?”

- 1 - PP
- 2 - BNG
- 3 - PSOE/PSdeG
- 4 - DO
- 5 - Vox
- 6 - Sumar Galicia
- 96 - Other
- 97 - None

P11 - Ideology

“In politics, the terms left and right are commonly used. Where would you place yourself on a scale from 0 to 10, where 0 means extreme left and 10 means extreme right?”

1 = Extreme left

...

10 = Extreme right

P12 - Territorial identity

“Which of the following statements best describes you?”

1 - I feel only Spanish

2 - I feel more Spanish than Galician

3 - I feel equally Spanish and Galician

4 - I feel more Galician than Spanish

5 - I feel only Galician

98 - Don't know / No answer

Note: Observations with category 98 are treated as missing in the analysis to use as a continuous variable

B.3 Key explanatory variables

P15 — Satisfaction with public services

“How satisfied are you with the following public services?”

(0 = not satisfied at all; 5 = fully satisfied)

Items:

Healthcare

Early and primary education

Secondary education (ESO, upper secondary, vocational training)

University education

Care for dependent persons

Housing

Environmental protection

Research, development, and innovation (R&D&i)

P27 - Knowledge of the foral fiscal system

“Do you know what the Basque–Navarre foral fiscal system consists of?”

1 - Yes, perfectly

2 - Yes, fairly well

3 - Not very well

4 - No

B.4 Socio-demographic variables

P1 — Gender

“What is your gender?”

1 - Male

2 - Female

P2 - Age

“How old are you?”

P4 - Education

“What is the highest level of education you have completed?”

- 1 - Low
- 2 - Medium
- 3 - Hight

P5 - Employment status

“Regarding your occupation and employment status, you are:”

- 1 - Self-employed / professional
- 2 - Private sector employee
- 3 - Public sector employee
- 4 - Retired / pensioner
- 5 - Student
- 6 - Performing household work
- 7 - Unemployed

P6 - Household size

“Number of people in your household (including yourself)”

P8 - Children in household

“Is there anyone in your household under 18 years old?”

- 1 - Yes
- 2 - No

P9 - Household income

“Currently, considering all members of your household (including yourself) and all sources of income, what is your average monthly gross household income?”

- 1 - Less than €1,000
- 2 - Between €1,000 and €2,000
- 3 - Between €2,001 and €3,000
- 4 - Between €3,001 and €5,000
- 5 - Between €5,001 and €8,000
- 6 - More than €8,001
- 98 - Don't know

Note: Observations with category 98 are treated as missing in the analysis